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Buddy Tate

Tenor saxophonist Buddy Tate is one of the oldest surviving alumni of the Count Basie Orchestra. Born George Holmes Tate on February 22, 1915, he grew up in Texas and later came to be known as one of the great "Texas Tenors" with Illinois Jacquet and Arnett Cobb. Buddy filled Herschel Evans' chair in the Basie band and stayed from 1939-49. After Basie, a gig at the Celebrity Room in New York led to a stay of twenty years. He can be heard on records with Basie, Jimmy Rushing, Jay McShann and with numerous groups under his own name. Count Basie was certainly thinking of Buddy when he said "the band has always been built from the rhythm, to the tenors and then to the rest of the band."

Buddy Tate was interviewed on March 3, 1995 in Scottsdale Arizona by Michael Woods. His daughter Georgette joined in part of the interview. Monk Rowe and Milt Fillius were also present during the interview.

MW: We are here filming a series of interviews with some of the greatest jazz musicians in our country, and we're building an archive of these video interviews for Hamilton College. We are here with Buddy Tate, one of the greatest tenor sax players who has ever lived, and a person who can tell us a great deal about experiences with the Count Basie band. Greetings.

BT: Thank you.

MW: I'd just like to open with a few questions. I'd like to ask you how did you first get attracted to the field of jazz? And how young were you when you started playing?

BT: Well I must have been about 14, between 14 and 16 years of age. And we had a family band in my home town in Sherman, Texas. And it was a nice little old band, it was a good band, and we would play towns like, well I'd say from Sherman to we'd go to Oklahoma City and Ardmore, Oklahoma, and places like that. And my first professional band that I worked with was with a band called T. Holders Twelve Clouds of Joy, who later became Andy Kirk's Twelve Clouds of Joy. And I left home with them when I was about, well between as I say 14 and 16, and went to the coldest place in the world, I felt, was Duluth, Minnesota, which it was fifty below zero. And I felt the world was coming to an end. And from there, where'd I go from Andy Kirk — from T. Holder I worked with Victoria Spivey's Tan Town Revue, and that's when, I think that's when I first met Lester, Lester Young. And he was with King Oliver, in Tulsa, Oklahoma. He came down and we had some sessions together. And from there I went back to T. Holder again, and off and on I worked with bands like Lucky Millinder, and Benny, Benny Goodman, and then I formed my own group, Celebrity Club, that was in Harlem, and I worked there for 21 years with my group. And from then on I've been doing solos and things like this, by myself, and

traveling more until I had several health problems, and that cut off the traveling. So that's where I am today, that's about it.

MW: And tell us now, when you started playing, what other things were there for youngsters to do? What was, because today there is a myriad of things but why did music seem to be attractive to you at that time? What other things could you have gone into?

BT: Well I really wanted to farm. We had a farm, and I lived on a farm, but my brother, I had two older brothers and one played piano, one played saxophone. But I always wanted to be a trombone player and I used to get the curtains off the wall and slide up and down on the wall. And so I wanted to be a trombone player actually, and my brother bought me a saxophone because I used to change and try to put his reeds and things on, you know, and I'd break them all up, so he says, "I bought you this saxophone and I'm going to try to get you a teacher." There wasn't many teachers in that town. And, "if you play anything it's going to be this." So that's actually what got me started playing the saxophone. A white friend of mine was playing and had a beautiful sound. And he used to play at the theaters and that was before talkies, and he played at the theater every day about 2:30, he'd go play at the theater. And I used to sit and listen — well I couldn't go to that theater, prejudice you know and racial things in those days — but I'd go out in the back and listen to him play, and he would tell me, I told him how pretty his sound was, he says, "yeah but I can't play no jazz." I said, "oh you can play jazz," I says. He says, "I heard you play some jazz," and he says, "if you teach me how to play jazz, I'll teach you how to read and play pretty." So we developed a very nice friendship and of course he got out of the music business.

MW: I want to ask you a question here. So then the music became a catalyst that was more important than the racial barrier 'cause he had something you wanted to learn and you had something he wanted to learn.

BT: That's right, that's true. And we got along fine because then I was playing alto, and he taught me how to transpose, he taught me a lot of things. And there was another boy, a black boy, that played trumpet and saxophone, but he loved carnivals and minstrel shows, and every time, if we didn't lock him up when the minstrel show come to town he'd be gone, you know, and his name was Emmet Malone. He was a very good arranger and everything. I don't know where he got the musical knowledge from, it was just sort of like a musical family too. And he could write, arrange. So from then on it's just been like you know.

MW: Let me ask you this. You mentioned this other player, you mentioned his tone, and you said you liked his tone. Would you consider that you also have a signature tone, where people can just hear your tone and know that's you?

BT: I try, I've tried for that to happen, and that's what I hope is coming across because we in those days we tried to be individual, to be say, oh, yeah, that's Buddy Tate, that's Herschel Evans. So that's what we tried to do then. And you know we didn't want to like if you got the same teacher, if everybody sounded the same, you didn't know who's who. So we didn't want it that way, you know? So I've tried to do it the way so they could say I could be identified.

MW: Now talk to us about when you first started with Basie.

BT: Well I was with Basie's first band in 1932 or 33, which was short-lived, and actually he was working with Benny Moten at that time. But Moten was having a lot of problems with getting work. So Basie got a job in I think it was Little Rock, Arkansas. And he came to Little Rock and I was there, and I worked with him there in that band.

MW: How did you meet? How did you audition for him or get that spot?

BT: Well, let's see I'm trying to think had I been with Andy Kirk? No, I don't think so. But he needed a tenor, and he wasn't too well known, you know? And he was glad for me to be with his band. Then I worked with that band. But later then he went back to Benny Moten, Hot Lips Page, all of those guys, they went back with Benny, with Benny Moten. So then when Benny Moten died — oh yeah, Walter Page, I don't want to leave him out, when Benny died, Basie was the one that took over the band, then he sent and got me to join him again. So and that's when I went back and worked with him I guess about 12 or 13 years off and on.

MW: And what year was this when you first started with the Basie band?

BT: And the first Basie band was in '33, the short-lived one. Then the next one was in '39 that I joined, 1939, and that was after he was famous. He was famous then in 1939 when I joined. Then I went and stayed about ten, twelve years.

MW: A question I wanted to ask you is, you know Basie has been quoted as saying that his band was developed from the rhythm section, and then up through the tenor sax positions, and then to the rest of the band.

BT: Yeah he loved tenors. You see in those days, you only had one tenor player, featured tenor player, but he always had two so he started out with Herschel and Lester. So he had two of the world's greatest and wasn't nobody — he had to make it. So when they went to New York they just chopped everybody down. And that rhythm section, he had Walt Page, Jo Jones, because that was all the American rhythm section, and himself, Freddie Green. That was quite a band.

MW: I wanted to ask you about that particular sound. There were different sounds, they say a different feel to the music that there was in the southwest than on the west coast or in the New York scene. Could you describe for us how you felt the sound of the Basie band was different?

BT: Well see like in New York bands, they could only play like in a fast tempo, something like this [hums]. Of course Basie came in and they could play like they called it in the midwest when [hums] and swing like that. But these other bands was up in here, and they would kill the chicks, you know the chorus girls and things, so when they brought the Basie band in and they started playing, they could throw legs and dance to that swing, and they said this is it! Where'd they come from? So and that's the way, that was, they called it the midwest — that's where that came from.

MW: So you say that feel is more relaxed?

BT: More relaxed but still swing. It was more swinging. And they was just having fits and jumping and having fits, and they would be swinging, and those guys would be taking those fine solos and things behind them. And it just swept the whole thing away. It was Chick Webb, well Chick played everything, it had to be up here, you know? It'd be up there, they'd have the midwest swing. Then come Jay McShann after, but they all had a different thing, had a different thing. Andy Kirk had more of a sweet band, people like Pha Tarrell, and Mary Lou [Williams]. They were swinging, but it was softer than Basie and people like that. They were good bands in Kansas City then. Musicians came out from New York who were supposed to be the big names, and they'd get a lesson when they'd come to Kansas City. They'd come from New York to Kansas City to get a lesson.

MW: You know I spent some time in that area myself, when you talk about Tulsa, Oklahoma, I spent ten years in Tulsa. And I noticed that the feel is different. It's more relaxed, it's got a nice bounce to it, but it doesn't sound so jumpy and hurried. And it's still kind of like that.

BT: Did you know — you know Ernie Fields then? I'm sure you know him.

MW: Yeah, I know Ernie Fields.

BT: Yeah. Fields, and Bostic, I think Bostic was from Tulsa. I hired Bostic in the T. Holder band. He was ahead of his time. He was some saxophone player. And who else? I think Little Ernie, I think somebody told me Ernie was still living.

MW: Well I left in '90 and he was still living.

BT: Yeah, I heard he was — how long ago was this?

MW: Four years.

BT: Yeah, I heard he was. Melvin Moore told me this. Did you know a singer by the name of Melvin Moore? He used to sing with Ernie Fields for a long time, and Don Albert out of San Antonio. And I think he told me that Ernie's still going, still around, with us.

MW: Tell us about some of your better recordings with the Basie band.

BT: I like this — well I'll tell you I like this song or recording date was called "Ham and Eggs" from the record you mean, you know like 78's, they weren't albums.

MW: Now were those records like you could only put three minutes on a side?

BT: Yeah. I think they later put them on some albums and things. There's some they got together and put them on. And there was a thing called "Silver Chief," "Ham and Eggs," and let's see what else, "Tickle Toe," that was with Lester [hums] do you remember that?

MW: I've been in bands that played arrangements of that.

BT: Yeah. I took the middle [hums]. That was my — that was Lester's "Tickle Toe." It was written for a piano.

MW: Tell us about that. Tell us about that.

BT: It was "Tickle Toe," it was in Tulsa, and I don't know he loved to hang around the musicians and everything, so we liked him very much. So Prez wrote a song, and named it "Tickle Toe."

MW: Can you tell us any other little stories like that around the titles of some of these songs? Cause isn't there a story about Moose the Mooch? The title of that song?

BT: The Mooch?

MW: No, Moose the Mooch, which was a guy who sold Charlie Parker his heroin? The guy that was supposed to be in a wheelchair?

BT: Yeah, I didn't know him.

MW: But there's little funny stories about some of the titles of these songs.

BT: Yeah, I didn't know him. We, there was one called, I remember, you remember Red Rodney?

MW: Yeah.

BT: They carried Red Rodney down south and they couldn't carry him down south, so they called him "The Albino" so they could take him down south with this black band. And so they called it "Albino Red."

MW: See now we're getting in to [sounds like] Otto King's world.

BT: Yeah, we just loved Red. You know, I think they went down there with Max [Roach], they went down with Bird, with Charlie Parker or somebody in there. They called him "Albino Red."

MW: I wanted to ask you a couple of other questions. Is jazz education today, is it up to the task, or were there things that you were learning inside the big bands that are different or supersede or are better or are structured in a different way than jazz education today?

BT: I think so.

MW: Can you give us an example.

BT: Because you see when like when they had the big bands, if you had like four or five saxophones you had to play together, just playing good didn't mean that you could fit in that band. You had to breathe together, the intonation had to be similar, and today you don't have that because you don't have many big bands. See there's no big bands and you don't have, it don't — there's great players, but I mean I'm not taking anything away

from them, I don't mean that. But I mean it's more than being great, you had to be able to blend together, and play together. So that would be the difference between today and yesterday.

MW: I wanted to ask you another question that kind of moves in with that concept too. And that is, you know, the difference between what we call oral culture and literate culture. Now literate culture of course means that you learn how to read notes and rhythms, and you learn how to write music down on paper. But jazz has always superseded what's on the page. Because it can't always show you what the inflection is on the page. Or it can't always show you when a note is being bent or when you put vibrato on it or when you put that note up in between two pitches and then slide it in, you know what I mean? Tell us about your experiences with oral culture and is it, are musicians being too professionally trained now to the place where some of that spice is gone out of it?

BT: I think at times it is because you're supposed to make mistakes, you understand? You'll get it better the next time. But you're supposed to — you can be too perfect I think. And then it takes the swing away, you know, if you're too perfect. But if — you see like you might come to work tonight and you feel like you're tearing the house down, and you really aren't getting off the ground as far as the people are concerned. And you come the next night and you feel like you're not doing anything and people come and says, "you knocked me out, boy you really cooked tonight." You know that's the way it is, that's just the way it is, it's an art. And you just can't do it all, you know it goes and comes. That's about the best way I can put it, I just — one night you're on, one night you're off. That's the best, I mean that goes with the best, you know? But there are some guys that I've played with, I don't think ever had a bad night.

MW: Give us an example.

BT: Well I didn't think Herschel had a bad night, Herschel Evans. I never thought he had a bad night. Of course Lester declined in his later years from health problems though, with Lester, and I never know what put him on the wrong track because for so many years he was just a health bug. And he was very unhappy with himself the last time we were together we played up to Newport Jazz Festival and he was very sick, he was drinking and drinking. And I rode back with him from Newport and we got lost, which Newport is ordinarily a two hour ride, but we got lost and it was all night. But I'm happy we did, because not knowing it was going to be my last time with him, you know. And he said to me that night he says, "you know I never really made it big." I said, "what are you talking about?" I ignored him at first, and he said, "did you hear what I said, I said I never really made it." I said, "what are you talking about" I says, "it's only two." I says, "they either play like you or play like Coleman Hawkins." So I says, "you got more imitators in the entire world." He says, "all the others are making the money" you know. He says, "I have

no eagle eyes," he says, "but I never really made any money." He didn't make any money that night.

MW: And that is another issue which I'd like you to elaborate on for a moment, and that is part of the structure of these interviews is also talking about how some of our greatest artists, particularly in jazz, don't get their due or don't get the respect that is afforded to rap artists or rock artists when what they do sometimes a great deal more artistic and actually costs them more in terms of the time and years they've put in in terms of study of their craft. When you started with the Basie band, what kind of money was a musician making at that time?

BT: Not much. The first band we weren't making anything. And in the latter band in 1939, we —

MW: What were you coming home with, a week, in your pocket?

BT: I'd say in the last band, you mean in the '39 band? Well it was better then, but not as ... what it should have been. We made several films and we would kind of get over, because we made "Hit Parade" of '43, with Dorothy Dandridge, and "Hellzapoppin" with Olson and Johnson I believe it was. Then we made some money with Ethel Waters, and was Lena Horne in there, I think she, no that was Cab in "Stormy Weather." But when we made those films and things we made —

MW: So you'd get royalties from that?

BT: No we didn't get no royalties, we would be paid a flat salary. [inaudible]

MW: Which is yet another issue —

BT: That's right, it should have been, but no. I don't even think Basie was getting any royalties, but it should have been, and you got paid and that was it.

MW: Now you talked about Lester saying he never felt that he never really made it big because I don't think he would have said that because of any lack in the power of his playing because he knew he had imitators, he knew that a lot of people were trying to play like him. But once again here we are at an issue where the musician is not receiving the diagnostic thing back that he needs. Other musicians will come up to him and say, "oh man I love the way you play," but he wasn't getting the feedback that he needed in other arenas, you know? Do you feel that you've gotten some of the respect that you deserve, and if you could have gotten more what would it have been?

BT: Well I don't know. I don't have too many, I don't have too many gripes really. I'm kind of satisfied with the way I've done. Because see when I got my, after I got my, when I organized my band, I was the leader and I paid the salaries. You know for 21 years I was on the job, you know, one job. So I kind of made it up there. But Prez used to say, he would refer to people, they wasn't no failure or anything but he acted like it. He referred, he says, "I don't know," he says, "all the ladies say they try to play like me, but they're

making all the money." He says, "I'm not making any money." So and he says, "sometimes I don't know if they're playing like me or I'm playing like them." You know he said kind of things like that, you know? So he really didn't make too much money because he was you know everybody was trying to stay out of the Army and a lot of musicians beat it because it was a lot of jobs and things then, you know with everybody going in, and the musicians just wasn't Army material, you know. So I remember one time we were out in California, and this little guy came out there that night and had his chain and zoot suit, and chain, you know like Cab used to wear and all that kind of stuff. So he sit and partied with us all night, me and Sweets, I mean Harry Edison, and Lester. And after, we would take our break, we'd come over and he'd buy everybody drinks and everything. And Prez was drinking pretty heavy then. And so at the end of the night he pulled it back like this and showed he was a policeman. He says, "I want you to be at the induction center tomorrow morning at 9 o'clock. I know where you live." And Prez had a heart attack almost, man. "Oh, my God" he says, "how could he be like that, I had confidence in the little guy, I started to give him a stick of pride." I says, "you wouldn't of been going through all of that," cause he didn't do to smoke pot, you know it started ringing too much. And you know he broke his heart, you know. So now they carried him down and sent him to Ft. Bragg, then they sent him to Alabama. And it was rough times in there. And he was down there trying to grow some marijuana patch and had him a little patch, and they put him in a brig and he told me he could only see through the hole about like that you know. And Norman Granz, you know the impresario, went down and got him out and he's the one that got him out. So he was down in Alabama so Norm says, you know, was telling him who he was and everything. And he's Jewish you know. They say, "well we don't care no more about you than we do about him." That's what they told him. He says, "yeah but if you mess with me you hear about it." So he got him out. But he went down after that.

MW: I want to ask you a question about jazz. You know we had talked, and you had talked about this too, how that in the early years of jazz of course before a certain time, like before Benny Goodman, all the bands were pretty much segregated, and then he began to hire Lionel Hampton and Teddy Wilson. But it seemed to me that the music was the one thing that allowed people to go back and forth without all these barriers, you know? Do you see a way that we can use music today to do the same things? Because it seems to me that in the past three or four years particularly, that the barriers are going up again almost. I'd like to see music —

BT: Be integrated more? Yeah, it should be. Well you know they have it in the smaller groups they don't have the big bands really to mix it more, with more, because we don't have big bands. But that's one thing that they never paid much attention to, you know? Of course

Benny would do what he wanted to do, and so did Jimmy, Jimmy Dorsey. He had a girl named, black girl named June Richmond and boy she could sing, boy. And he brought her from California all through Texas and everywhere with him. So you've got to give him credit for that. This was Jimmy, not Tommy, Jimmy, his brother, you know? And of course Tommy had Charlie Shavers writing in his band, and Sy Oliver was writing all these arrangements. So there was more integration, more. Of course we had more musicians and as I say you had bigger bands and things like that. So I don't know, let's see whose got a small group and got it integrated, let's see — Nancy? I think she's got an integrated small group. And Carmen McRae — Carmen had an integrated small group. So you know it's just, the integration is according like with the time now, because you don't have big bands, you don't have many integrated musicians because of that.

MW: A couple of last questions I would like to ask you. Was the Basie band the best big band there ever was?

BT: Swinging. I thought so. I thought it was. Because it could, it could basically sit right here in this room and swing like a dog, and the room didn't have to be no bigger than this. And he could keep the band down and be swinging like crazy. And I thought he had, I thought he had about the best swinging band.

MW: One last question I would like to ask you is if you could give a word to the field of music, if you wanted to leave a word behind, a word of wisdom, to younger musicians who would come after you and learn something from you, what would you tell them, about tone, about phrasing, about music, about spirit?

BT: Well I would tell them to practice and listen, don't think you know it all, always listen because everybody's got something to say. And keep swinging. I tell them keep trying to blow and always listen, because everybody's got something to say, and never think you know it all.

MW: So you've got to stay hungry.

BT: You've got to stay hungry. Yeah. Never know it all.

MW: Do you have a funny little story about the Basie band that you could leave us with? Or anything that happened? Al asked me to talk to you about one night that you and another player got lost or got left behind or something on a trip?

BT: With Basie?

MW: Yeah.

BT: No, I got left behind with the Nat Towles' band many times because Towl would leave sometimes and it wouldn't be nobody but him. If we was supposed to leave at a certain time he would leave, and he left us, left me and Henry Coker, who later became a great trombone player man, and he left us in DesMoines, Iowa or somewhere. And we went out and picked pockets, somebody picked pockets, and we got our money back and more. I

learned. And I tried to pull Coker's coat you know, because I had seen this happen. You know whatever you say you get pickpocket, you had to make it good, so and I knew this and I had seen this happen you know? So I think we got pickpocket for about $15 apiece, but no money man, you know? So we wake up and everybody's gone and the money's gone, and when I went to the landlord of the house and told him that we didn't have any money and what have you. So he cursed us out and everything. So I says okay. So I went on down to the police station and the policeman, the captain there was a trumpet player. He says, "I know where you were." See he called the name of the house, he says, "come on." And he put us in a corner and carried us back in there, and they were sitting around in there gambling and having a good time. He went in and he says "now I let you all operate, gamble, do everything you want, but when you start that stealing, I'll close your house down right now." So and he says, "what did you say you lost?" I said, "$30." I say, "he did too." He says, "no I ain't lose but $15." I said, "you had the same thing I did." I kept it right up there. He says, "no I didn't have but $15." But I laughed.

MW: Allow for a little inflation, huh?

BT: So they give us that money so the policeman says, "now what do you all want to do, do you want to stay here or do you want us to take you to the train station?" I says, "I want you to take us to the bus station and stay with us until that bus gets rid of me. Because I know them cats man, and I know them cats will send somebody after us." So they put us on the bus and we went on to Omaha. And I wouldn't speak to Towles no more, I didn't speak to him for about a week and I wouldn't play with him or anything like that because he's wild, from Memphis, you know.

[pause]

MW: We're back and we're going to ask some more questions here and try to find out a few more colorful things with out guest, Buddy Tate. We would like to ask you, Georgette, if the two of you can kind of recall some experiences for us, perhaps like this?

GT: I have many, many happy stories of my father.

MW: Share one of them.

GT: When you're raised with musicians, actors, singers, they are — I think that song best describes it that there's no people like show people, and it's true. He doesn't like to hear this, I think they're all rather shy like that. But as the children and as how we see it, they are different, they are special. And they are great, if I had all the money in the world I wouldn't trade it for him as a father. He's been my best friend, my advisor, he's a very sensitive person and he's a very wise man. I think as teenagers, you know how we can be when we're young we feel like we know it all, but as I got older I really began to see how wise he was, if ever I have questions. But there's so many funny stories. I remember when we were in California, I was about three years old, and he tells me this, I vaguely

remember it, when he was making a movie. And I've always been a night owl, because he'd always get home at two or three and I'd always wait with him and we'd have breakfast early in the morning and I thought that was hot stuff. And he'd come home. And I heard something about movies, and I knew this, and I started to, my mother, he got up and I jumped up and I got my bag and I had my hat, and I was packing and trying to get ready and putting my shoes on the wrong feet, and Daddy always tells this story much funnier than I do, and my mother said something to the effect of, "why don't you tell her that she's not going." And I knew, California, Hollywood, I knew that at three. And he said, "you tell her." I remember this fair.

BT: She says, "Mother, I see you're not going. I'm going with Daddy." She was about three years old. So she says, "I see you're not going." And she says, "but I'm going." So I couldn't take her though, at that time of morning, because we were making this picture, I don't know if it was "Hellzapoppin" with Dorothy Dandridge. Anyway, but she wanted to go. She wanted to go everywhere I'd go. And I remember the night she was born, I wanted to see her to visit, and I was working, it was just about the time we were working at the Panther Room in Chicago and she called up and we'd have to go to work early in the afternoon. So one night I said, Basie says, "well go by there and talk to the lady." So we went by there, and there she was, awake, at 3:00 in the morning. So and the lady says, "I could lose my job for this." I said, "but I want to see my little girl" I says, "I haven't seen her." So she says, "okay, come on, cause Basie's my favorite band." So she let me see her and there she was, winking her eye. She used to wink her eye like this. I don't know where she got that from. She used to be winking when I had her, she'd be winking and all. And people on the subway, I'd have her on the subway in New York and she'd be winking the eye and they'd break up the subway, cause people just couldn't understand. They'd be holding her.

GT: There's a story I remember traveling with Basie and at that time they traveled on the trains and this is when they had the berth that you could sleep in. And then you'd have, every morning the wives with the kids of all the musicians would come and we'd come to breakfast. And there was Snooky, played the trumpet with Basie at the time, and then Earle Warren, and I'd have names for all of them. Well musicians have names for each other, Smiley, and Sweets —

BT: Cateye was Buck.

GT: Buck Clayton.

BT: Dickie Wells

GT: They all had names for each other. But now I knew they all had names so I started naming them. And I used to call Earle Warren "Egghead" and Sweets, he always would take me to get strawberry ice cream, but I always bothered him. He said, "you always bug

— there's your father, go ask your father." And I said, "no I want you to get me the strawberry ice cream." Because he had all this money.

BT: He would be asleep, and I would be asleep, and she wouldn't. See we'd be on the train and she'd wake him up and so he says, "tell your father to go get it for you, Georgia," he says, "I don't want to."

GT: [inaudible] But I remember Sweets' daughter, not Sweets, it was Snooky. He had three kids there was Pepper, Judy and there was another, we had a difference in age. And a lot of us, the parents would pack the lunches, and I remember we would wait, it was like after when they'd all settle down, we would go in and pull these boxes down and Pepper, Snooky's son, would pull down the cake and the cake was all over him and then we would get in trouble. You know we were always, there were so many of us I can remember different members of the band the kids when we traveled. I remember once I pulled away from my mother and my father. And I was with —

BT: Freddie?

GT: Freddie Green and the trains would come in and they would stop, you know, abruptly back and forth, and between where you stepped from the curb to the train there was an opening, it wasn't closed off. And I slipped under somehow. And I remember he just came, I don't know where he was, but he came and pulled me up and I remember being very upset about it.

BT: Yes, scared to death, me too.

GT: And I threw up. But anyway I remember more than falling under the train was I had on this slip —

BT: [inaudible] But you know somebody would always take her. So but the trouble is the train would be, you know how they're [sounds like] yilking and shaking, and she just fell down under, and almost fell under.

GT: I was so embarrassed because I had my slip on, and I said, "why is everybody asking me these questions and they see I have on my slip." That's all I could think about. And my mother said, "are you all right?" "I'm fine." And you know they were worried. But I was concerned that everybody saw me in my slip. I mean these are the kind of stories that Judy and I would, we would, it was always an experience. Always, always. I remember Basie would play and they had a show and there was chorus girls and they had great big satin balls. And the girls would be on top of the ball and they would come across. And I remember Pepper and I, we saw our parents playing on stage, and we didn't know the show had started, and we ran out on stage, and then we look out and there was all these people —

BT: In the big Roxy Theater.

GT: And they were looking at us. And everybody start to laugh and then we'd laugh. And then they'd clap and then we'd clap. And Basie said, "would you please" —

BT: The Roxy Theater.

GT: I can remember all the lights and all the beautiful people. I remember so many, I remember Lena, watching her make up her face, and saying when I get big I want to be like her. I remember, oh, I can't think of her name you just said it — Carmen?

BT: Mary Grace?

GT: No, as a child I think, Dinah Washington —

BT: Sass?

GT: Sarah Vaughan, I met them all, and I loved Billie Holiday. I loved Billie. She was, I just loved Billie she was special, very special.

BT: Yes she had ... her choice of songs were different. She would sing like "Good Morning Heartache," and she'd pick the right songs, and just for her. I guess it was because she'd lived a, you know, a sad life. And "Good Morning Heartache," "Fine and Mellow," and what was the next one she sang she used to do, I can't even remember, but I dug her choice. Nat King Cole was another one, picked the right songs to sing.

MW: I wanted to ask you, in traveling with the band, from city to city, was there a camaraderie there? Was there a communal quality there that is somehow missing in some of our neighborhoods and societies now?

GT: That's a very good question. In — there's different cultures, like he was saying, in your swing bands in the west, there's different cultures say from Texas, California, from when you go midwest and you come north, yes, there's a difference. One of the great things about traveling is that you're constantly learning and when you're not even aware of it.

MW: Travel is its own education.

GT: Yes, in itself, in itself.

BT: Yeah, when you travel and you've seen it, you can read about books and things like that but they don't know it all, you've seen it, if you've seen it and done it, you know can nobody tell you any more about it you know? And I don't know...

MW: The reason why I ask that is this is because you know I remember when I was a kid I had heroes, and whenever I got to see those heroes play or sing, it's like that set me on another level. And for me, I didn't get in on the big band thing. For me it was Motown. So every year, that's where I was coming from. But when my heroes came to town, that was really something for me.

GT: That's something special.

MW: And what I was thinking and what I wanted to tie into that is I would really like to see a lot more of the younger, particularly the younger black musicians, respect some of the finer artists that made some of this music come to life. And I think they could learn a lot

and not bump their heads in the same spots, if they would learn and if they would respect the artistry that's there.

BT: They were trying, blacks were trying to get away from the blues, and the whites were learning to sing the blues.

GT: In Europe they were.

BT: They were singing the Blues, like Mamie Smith, Bessie Smith, Ma Rainey and all of them you know, and they were trying to get away from it. Like what was that other one [sings] If you had plenty money, like 1922, you wouldn't be here, why don't you do right like the other folk do, go out and give me some money too. That was made by Ma Rainey, and she was older than Mamie Smith. I worked with Mamie, in later years. And she was older than Mamie Smith. And they didn't make no money on that. Many did, and Peggy did, she sang it with him. But it was originally, it was originally Ma Rainey's tune.

MW: Any other little anecdotes you'd like to give us?

GT: Oh, I can't think of. As he was talking I was thinking of stories that he told me and I can think of things, and I'm trying to think of stories.

MW: I will share with you something that influenced me, and I don't know if you have these, you probably do in some way. But when I was a kid some people asked me they said, "where did you get your sounds from?" And I said, "well I didn't get it from music school, even though I have a doctorate degree in music. I got it from being a kid and my mother listening to the radio on Sunday morning." And I remember the smell of sausage and fried potatoes, you know, just like on the cartoons where smoke comes off the pan and goes up the stairs and tickles you on the nose? And I remember the smell of fried potatoes and sausage, and my mother would be, if it was Sunday morning, she'd be listening to the Gospel, and that would be like The Mighty Clouds of Joy and Five Blind Boys and Dixie Hummingbirds. And if it was Sunday night it would be Sam Cooke, it would be Clyde McPhatter, it would be the early R&B artists. And I connected the taste of the soul food, and the sounds, and my mother in the kitchen singing, and that's where my sounds go back to. And they supersede what I learned in a book, you know what I mean. Tell us some of your early inspirations like that.

BT: Well, I would listen to, speaking of big bands, there was Alphonso Trent and Coon-Sanders, they used to come from Kansas City's white band, original Night Hawks, they had a hell of a band. And who else?

MW: Was Trent out of Oklahoma City?

BT: No, Alphonso Trent was actually, they were really ahead of their time. They were from, he's from Arkansas, but he was rich, he was from this family that had plenty money and they had all kinds of uniforms, they were sharp looking cats, and they'd go in those white hotels and stay a year. They went in the Adolphus Hotel, where there were no blacks in

those hotels, then they'd go to San Antonio, to the Gunter, and they appeared at all those hotels and things like that. So that's why I always wanted to be with Trent, you know because of this, they had a good reputation and they never got stranded like bands were getting stranded there in those days, in big cars and all like that. Of course they had to take the freight elevator when they come to work, they'd look like the guests at the Adolphus Hotel, but when they got on that stand, the first drummer I ever seen, a solo drummer, was a drummer by the name of A.G. Godley. Buddy Rich loved him, Jo Jones loved him, all the drummers knew about A.G. Godley. And the band got off the bandstand, and he'd play for about 10-15 minutes by himself, changing rhythms all the time.

GT: He has a large picture of Alphonso Trent's band. And I remember looking at these musicians, and he's not one to brag, but he always said he had the sharpest band in the world, because they dressed, they had uniforms, and they were all good looking, very handsome men. And when we lived in Manhattan before we moved to Long Island, one of my girlfriends name was Joanie Cook and her father played for Trent, I mean for Alphonso. And I can remember thinking to myself when I was ten, I must have been around ten, he was very tall, very handsome, they said all those men that was in that band was handsome. And I remember, it applied, with Joan's father, that they were all. And certain stories he'll tell when he feels like talking.

BT: Treating people's wives and things —

MR: I've got a picture here, and see what you can remember about that? 1940?

BT: I sure do, yes sir. That was made I'm trying to remember where. Let's see Page is in here, Walter Page.

MR: Do you remember that night?

BT: I'm trying to see. No I was thinking this would be made at Treasure Island in Los Angeles, remember when they had Treasure Island in 1939? You people too young.

MF: San Francisco.

BT: San Francisco, that's right. No it wasn't there. I don't know where this was.

GT: If it says the year maybe you could —

MR: I think it says Savoy Ballroom, New York.

BT: Might be in Savoy Ballroom, 1940, 1939. It might have been the Savoy Ballroom. It might have been 1939 but it says 1940. Edison's here. Ed Lewis, Buck Clayton. Vic Dickenson, Dickie Wells, Dan Minor. There's some heavy cats in there. Freddie, Tab Smith, Tab always loved, music-wise he loved Basie's band, but Lucky didn't care nothing about no money. What Basie was paying $250 a week, Lucky would give them $500. That's the way he was if he wanted a musician. And his mother worked for Al Capone. And so he never worried about no money. And when Capone and all of them

people, they were very afraid about Lucky. So Lucky said one time they were playing well he was running around Chicago just by himself singing and singing from club to club, so his mother worked for Al Capone, and he always talked with a cigar in his mouth in the corner of his mouth and then would take it out when he talked you know. So he says, "Clare, what did Lucky want." She says, "oh he didn't want anything" she says, "he's all right, Mr. Capone." He says, "I mean something big — I want him to have something big, I like Lucky." So Lucky says, "tell him to come to dinner tonight." So Lucky say he went to dinner and he says, "Lucky, I want you to have something big." So and he says, "well I'd like to have a band someday, Mr. Capone, some day I'd like to have my own band." So and he says, "you want a band?" He says that night, in one of his clubs, he had a band by the name of Walter Bonds, they were all burned and they were dying in Florida a few years later And he says he went to work and when he went there that night, he said he walked right up to the bandstand, and pulled Lucky by the, pulled Walter Bonds by the tail of his tuxedo and told him to come down, and took Lucky like this and put him up there. He gave him about $400 and said I want Lucky to have this band, you go get another band. He took that man's band in 20 minutes. He wanted Lucky to have that band. I remember Lucky when, of course when Lucky passed he had flowers from here to that corner, from Ralph Capone, Al's brother. And he dropped on the streets, of a heart attack, just — he had a thousand dollars in his pocket, and when they carried him to the hospital he was so well liked, he had his thousand dollars, nobody got it. On 125th Street in New York, and he was, all them flowers, big as that like — yeah, he was in with them. So and this was the boy he liked was Tab Smith. That's the one. And he was playing with Lucky.

MW: What size was the band at that time? Who was —

BT: Well, we got about one, two, three, got five saxes. One, two three. Let's see Prez, Jack, yeah, there's five saxes. One, two, three, four, five. Five saxophones. And maybe four or five trombones. There's Sweets and Buck. Vic Dickenson, Dan Minor.

MW: It seems to me that the players at that time were not only good players, but real personalities.

BT: Yeah, you know you had to, had to be nice too, you know because if you didn't, you didn't get the gig, you know? You had to do more than just play. You had to be a nice person, because we had a lot of friends, you know, and that's what they wanted you to have. They used to say, well Basie was just a, Basie was just a cat, a down to earth cat. There was much difference between he and Duke. Duke was a beautiful cat, but he associated with bigger people, you know, like doctors and things like that. You might catch Basie in an alley with crap shooters. And Lunceford was more like Duke, you know, only he had his, Lunceford had his nose in the air though, he was a school teacher

and he wanted the band to be just students, I mean school kids like. There was a lot of different personalities and things.

MW: Tell us one of the, if you can share with us, who do you think was, if you were assigning personalities to the band, who would have been the class clown of the band?

BT: Clown?

MW: Yeah.

BT: Like that did the funny things?

MW: Yeah.

BT: I would say Ray Nance in the later years with Duke, then before Ray Nance was a guy named Freddie Jenkins. He was with Duke. And they would do funny things you know, in the band. Those would be my two greatest ones I think. We had Ray and Freddie. Ray Nance'd be laughing all night.

MW: And I would like to ask you if you have a final anecdote you'd like to leave us with.

GT: Well, I just would like to say that I, you ask some very interesting questions, and they were very valid and they were very good questions. And as far as jazz is concerned I think here we don't appreciate it here in America and it's not fair to the young people here. I know in Europe and in London and in France, kids in high school, 13, 14, 15 years old are very well informed on jazz, of jazz musicians in the 30's, 40's, 50's, they know this like it's nothing. And here we are where jazz originated from here in America, and I don't think our students here, it's not fair to them to say they don't know is not fair well they're not informed. That's something that we've done. That's something that it's not fair to them and I think we owe it to them and they're not informed. And I think as Americans and as adults, we're missing something and we're allowing a great history to slip away. It's a dying art and I don't think it's fair that you have to go to Europe to find out about your own musicians and not just musicians, but it's so many people of the 40's. They don't let their history die, whether it's art, whether it's — and the drama department and it's music, they're creative and they respect it and they nurture it and the young students in school is aware, they're constantly aware of what's going on and they know their past and we don't treasure ours. And I think it's something we're doing wrong and we should correct it.

MW: Two things. First of all I agree with you wholeheartedly. One thing that we're, this documentary, as Milt Fillius has shared with us many times, was developed specifically because of those reasons. Because he felt like young people don't honor their icons the way they should, and we are trying to see that some more of that happens. The other thing is you know if you don't admit that what you have yourself is great, no one else will either. So I think it's time that America say yes, these are great artists and they do

bring a tremendous wealth to our culture and we have to honor them and honor them while they're getting there.

BT: Yeah. While they can smell the flowers, huh?

MW: That's right, that's the truth. And so we're going to wrap up this interview at this time, and it's been wonderful having Buddy Tate with us and Georgette, and

BT: And Mary.

MW: Who we didn't get on camera, yes, and we're going to continue to do these interviews over a period of time, and hopefully make a difference in the cultural life of America.

BT: It's been my pleasure. Thank you so much, Mike.